



Japan — Days Per City Planner

*Based on POI count, travel time between spots, and a comfortable "take your time" pace. Total: **28 days** | See `japan_poi.md` for individual POI time estimates.*

Summary Table

City	Type	Days	Cumulative	Notes
Tokyo	Base	8	8	Includes Nikko day trip
Nikko	Day trip (from Tokyo)	1	—	Counted inside Tokyo days
Kyoto	Base	6	14	Includes Nara day trip
Nara	Day trip (from Kyoto)	1	—	Counted inside Kyoto days
Osaka	Base	3	17	
Hiroshima & Miyajima	Base	2	19	
Kanazawa	Base	2	21	
Okinawa	Base	4	25	Fly from Kanazawa or Osaka
Tokyo (final buffer)	Buffer	3	28	Shopping, rest, flight prep
TOTAL		28	28	



TOKYO — 8 Days

Includes 1 day trip to Nikko (7 days in the city itself)

Why 8 days

Tokyo is enormous. Even with a tight itinerary, the sheer size of the city means each neighborhood is a half or full day on its own. With Ghibli Museum, Akihabara, teamLab, and all the main sights, 8 days allows a genuinely relaxed pace plus a proper deep-dive into old-town neighborhoods.

Suggested Day Breakdown

Day	Focus	Key POIs
Day 1	East Tokyo (temples + old city)	Senso-ji, Kaminarimon, Nakamise, Ueno Park, Ameyoko Market
Day 2	Anime & Pop Culture	Akihabara, Nakano Broadway, Pokemon Center
Day 3	West Tokyo (parks + shrines)	Meiji Jingu, Yoyogi Park, Harajuku, Shibuya Crossing, Shibuya Sky
Day 4	Ghibli + teamLab	Ghibli Museum (morning), teamLab Planets or Borderless (evening)
Day 5	Day trip → Nikko	Tosho-gu, Rinnoji, Kegon Falls, Lake Chuzenji
Day 6	Modern Tokyo + Judo	Kodokan Judo Institute, Tokyo Skytree, Odaiba, Omoide Yokocho
Day 7	Old-town neighborhoods	Yanaka shitamachi, Shimokitazawa vintage shops, Koenji
Day 8	Flexible	Roppongi (Mori Art Museum), Ginza, extra shopping, or rest

Time budget check

POI	Est. Time
Senso-ji + Nakamise + Asakusa stroll	2 hrs
Ueno Park + Ameyoko	2 hrs
Akihabara deep dive	4–5 hrs
Nakano Broadway	2–3 hrs
Meiji Jingu + Harajuku	2 hrs
Shibuya area (crossing + Sky)	3 hrs
Ghibli Museum	2–3 hrs
teamLab Planets	1.5–2 hrs
Kodokan Judo Institute	1–2 hrs
Tokyo Skytree	1.5–2 hrs
Yanaka + Shimokitazawa stroll	3–4 hrs
Nikko (full day trip)	8–9 hrs incl. transit

Total across 8 days: ~46–52 hrs of POI time → comfortable at ~6–7 hrs/day



KYOTO — 6 Days

Includes 1 day trip to Nara (5 days in Kyoto itself)

Why 6 days

Kyoto has the highest density of UNESCO World Heritage sites in Japan. Fushimi Inari alone takes a half day. The city rewards a slow pace — rushing it is one of the most common Japan travel regrets. A 6th day allows a proper deep-dive into hidden sub-temples, mountain villages, and a leisurely Pontocho evening.

Suggested Day Breakdown

Day	Focus	Key POIs
Day 1	Southern Kyoto (shrines)	Fushimi Inari Taisha (early morning), To-ji Temple, Nishiki Market
Day 2	Higashiyama (eastern temples)	Kiyomizu-dera, Sanjusangen-do, Ginkaku-ji, Philosopher's Path
Day 3	Northern Kyoto	Kinkaku-ji, Ryoan-ji, Daitoku-ji, Nijo-jo Castle
Day 4	Arashiyama + Gion	Bamboo Grove (dawn), Sagano Train, Tenryu-ji, Gion at dusk
Day 5	Day trip → Nara	Nara Park, Todai-ji, Kasuga Taisha, Kofuku-ji
Day 6	Hidden Kyoto + mountain villages	Kibune & Kurama (half-day hike), Pontocho dinner, Toei Studio Park (optional)

Time budget check

POI	Est. Time
Fushimi Inari (full mountain)	3–4 hrs
Kinkaku-ji	1–1.5 hrs
Kiyomizu-dera + surrounding streets	2 hrs
Philosopher's Path walk	1–1.5 hrs
Arashiyama Bamboo Grove	1 hr
Nijo-jo Castle	1.5–2 hrs
Gion evening stroll	1.5–2 hrs
Kibune & Kurama half-day	3–4 hrs
Nara full day trip	6–7 hrs incl. transit

Total across 6 days: ~36–42 hrs of POI time → ~6–7 hrs/day

NARA — Day Trip (from Kyoto)

Why 1 day

Nara's must-see spots are clustered tightly around the park. A dedicated day lets you visit all key temples and spend real time with the deer without rushing.

Suggested Schedule

Time	Activity
8:00	Depart Kyoto (30 min by express train)
8:45	Arrive Nara; walk to Nara Park — deer are most active in the morning
9:00	Nara Park + deer crackers
10:30	Todai-ji Temple (Great Buddha)
12:00	Lunch near Nishiki-koji area
13:00	Kasuga Taisha Shrine
14:00	Kofuku-ji Temple + Sarusawa Pond
15:00	Isuien Garden (optional)
16:00	Return to Kyoto



OSAKA — 3 Days

Why 3 days

Osaka's main draw is street food and entertainment. USJ alone requires a full day. The castle + Dotonbori fills another. The third day covers the Namba food scene and Umeda.

Suggested Day Breakdown

Day	Focus	Key POIs
Day 1	USJ — full day	Universal Studios Japan, Nintendo World
Day 2	History + street food	Osaka Castle, Shinsekai, Dotonbori, Kuromon Market
Day 3	Food + architecture	Tenjinbashisuji, Umeda Sky Building, Osaka Aquarium

Time budget check

POI	Est. Time
USJ (full day)	8–10 hrs
Osaka Castle	1.5–2 hrs
Dotonbori + street food	2–3 hrs
Kuromon Market	1 hr
Osaka Aquarium	2–3 hrs
Umeda Sky Building	1 hr

Total: ~18–22 hrs across 3 days → ~6–7 hrs/day

HIROSHIMA & MIYAJIMA — 2 Days

Why 2 days

One day for Hiroshima city (Peace Park + Museum is emotionally heavy — don't rush it), one full day for Miyajima island. Trying to do both in one day is too rushed.

Suggested Day Breakdown

Day	Focus	Key POIs
Day 1	Hiroshima city	Peace Memorial Park, Atomic Bomb Dome, Museum, Hiroshima Castle, Shukkeien Garden
Day 2	Miyajima Island	Ferry to island, Itsukushima Shrine, Daisho-in Temple, oyster lunch, hike Mt. Misen (optional)

Time budget check

POI	Est. Time
Peace Memorial Park + Dome	1.5–2.5 hrs
Peace Memorial Museum	1.5–2 hrs
Hiroshima Castle	1 hr
Miyajima full island day	6–8 hrs
Ferry to/from Miyajima	1 hr round trip

NIKKO — Day Trip (from Tokyo)

Why 1 day

Nikko's shrines are clustered in one area at the base of the mountains. A full day is enough to visit Toshogu, the other shrines, and Kegon Falls with a bus ride up to Lake Chuzenji.

Suggested Schedule

Time	Activity
7:00	Depart Tokyo (Asakusa Station → Tobu Nikko, 2 hrs)
9:30	Arrive Nikko; walk up to shrine complex
10:00	Rinnoji Temple
10:45	Toshogu Shrine (main complex)
12:30	Lunch near Shinkyo Bridge area
13:30	Bus up to Chuzenji-ko (Lake Chuzenji)
14:00	Kegon Waterfall (elevator) + lake walk
15:30	Bus back to Nikko town
16:00	Taiyuin Mausoleum (quieter; don't skip)
17:00	Train back to Tokyo

OKINAWA — 4 Days

Why 4 days

Okinawa is completely different from mainland Japan — distinct culture, food, and landscape. The main island needs 2 days; a day trip to Kerama Islands is essential for snorkeling; the northern Yanbaru area needs a separate day.

Suggested Day Breakdown

Day	Focus	Key POIs
Day 1	Naha city	Shuri Castle, Kokusai-dori, Makishi Public Market, Seifa-utaki
Day 2	Central Okinawa	Nakagusuku Castle Ruins, Cape Manzamo, American Village area
Day 3	Kerama Islands day trip	Ferry from Naha; snorkeling, beaches, coral reefs
Day 4	North — Yanbaru	Yanbaru National Park, Cape Hedo (northernmost point), scenic drive

Time budget check

POI	Est. Time
Shuri Castle	1.5–2 hrs
Kokusai-dori + Makishi Market	2 hrs
Seifa-utaki	1 hr
Nakagusuku Ruins	1 hr
Cape Manzamo	45 min
Kerama Islands (day trip)	6–8 hrs
Yanbaru NP	4–5 hrs

KANAZAWA — 2 Days

Why 2 days

Often called "Little Kyoto," Kanazawa is compact but rich. Two days lets you cover Kenroku-en, the castle, Higashi Chaya, the 21st Century Museum, and Omicho Market at a relaxed pace.

Suggested Day Breakdown

Day	Focus	Key POIs
Day 1	Garden + castle + market	Kenroku-en Garden (morning), Kanazawa Castle Park, Omicho Market (lunch), Higashi Chaya (afternoon/evening)
Day 2	Art + culture	21st Century Museum of Contemporary Art, Nagamachi Samurai District, Nishi Chaya District



TOKYO FINAL — 3 Days (Buffer)

Why 3 days

- **Day 1:** Any POIs you missed in the first Tokyo week; Shinjuku shopping
- **Day 2:** DisneySea (if not done), Kabuki-za, or Roppongi
- **Day 3:** Packing, flight prep, Narita/Haneda transfer

Never schedule your last day before a flight as a full POI day — leave it as a buffer.

Full 28-Day Calendar Grid

WEEK 1 (Days 1-8): TOKYO

- D1 East Tokyo – Asakusa, Ueno
- D2 Akihabara / Pop Culture
- D3 West Tokyo – Harajuku, Shibuya
- D4 Ghibli Museum + teamLab
- D5 Day trip: NIKKO
- D6 Modern Tokyo – Kodokan, Skytree, Odaiba
- D7 Yanaka shitamachi + Shimokitazawa vintage shopping
- D8 Flexible – Roppongi / Ginza / extra rest

WEEK 2 (Days 9-14): KYOTO

- D9 Travel Tokyo→Kyoto (Shinkansen ~2h15m) + Fushimi Inari
- D10 Higashiyama temples
- D11 Northern Kyoto – Kinkakuji, Ryoanji, Nijo-jo
- D12 Arashiyama + Gion evening
- D13 Day trip: NARA
- D14 Hidden Kyoto – Kibune & Kurama, Pontocho dinner

DAYS 15-17: OSAKA

- D15 Travel Kyoto→Osaka (15 min) + Dotonbori + Kuromon
- D16 USJ – full day
- D17 Osaka Castle + Aquarium + Umeda

DAYS 18-19: HIROSHIMA & MIYAJIMA

- D18 Travel Osaka→Hiroshima (Shinkansen 1h30m) + Peace Park + Museum
- D19 Miyajima Island full day

DAYS 20-21: KANAZAWA

- D20 Travel Hiroshima→Kanazawa (Shinkansen via Osaka, ~3h) + Kenroku-en
- D21 21st Century Museum + Higashi Chaya + Omicho Market

DAYS 22-25: OKINAWA

- D22 Fly Kanazawa→Naha (~2h) + Naha city – Shuri Castle, Kokusai-dori
- D23 Central Okinawa – Cape Manzano, Nakagusuku
- D24 Kerama Islands day trip (snorkeling)
- D25 Yanbaru National Park

DAYS 26-28: TOKYO (FINAL BUFFER)

D26 Fly Naha→Tokyo + arrive, rest
D27 DisneySea OR missed Tokyo spots
D28 Shopping + packing + airport

See `japan_poi.md` *for individual POI details and entry fees* | See
`japan_budget.md` *for costs* Last updated: May 2026